A STAY SAFE MANIFESTO

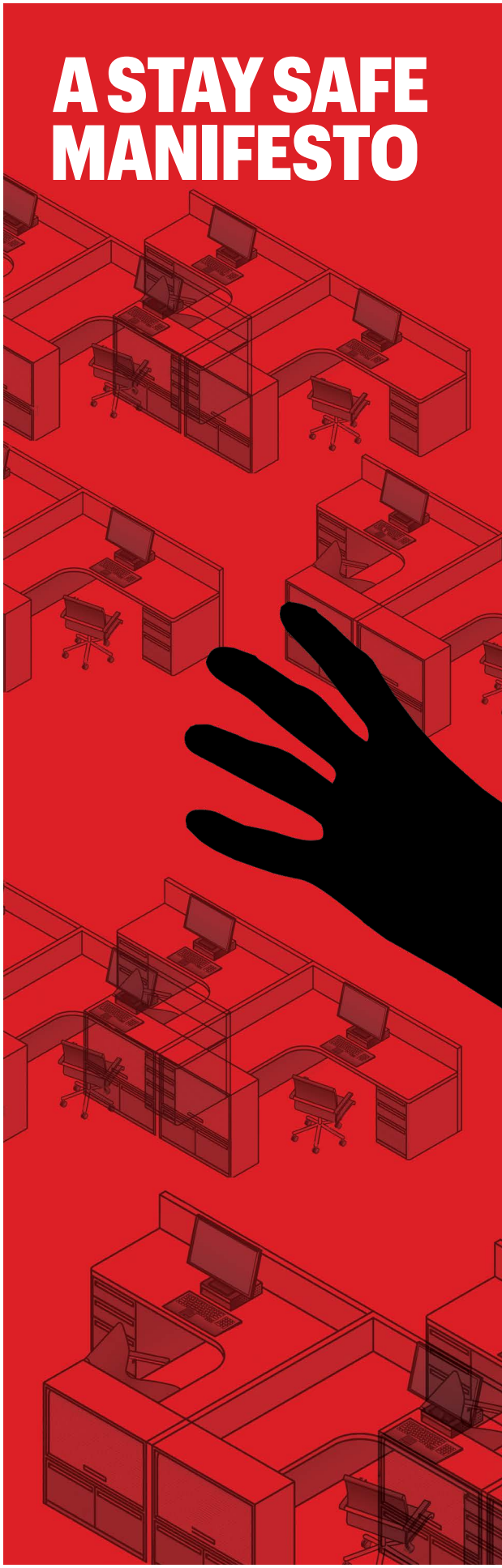


Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

Abhaya lives. The nationwide outrage that broke out over the bestial rape and murder of a 31-year-old trainee doctor at a prominent state-run hospital, the R.G. Kar Medical Centre and Hospital, in Kolkata on August 9, just refuses to die. Till justice, it seems, is done not just for her but for the millions of women across the country who work in offices, factories or in the services sector, in increasingly unsafe working conditions. Gruesomely attacked at her place of work, the death of Abhaya—the name given to the doctor to protect her identity—has brought into sharp focus the prevailing callousness and apathy towards ensuring the safety of a growing number of women in their workplaces. The fear, and the fury, persist. "What happened in Kolkata could easily happen to any of us residents," says a young resident doctor in a prominent Delhi hospital. "We all take short naps in empty halls or classrooms during night shifts. And when the toilets are too dirty, we walk out and use public restrooms in cafes or petrol pumps at night."

Nor is it specific to any one sector. Judge the furore that erupted all around over the revelations of the Hema Committee's report about the sexual exploitation of actresses in the Malayalam film industry (see *The Rot in Mollywood*). A #MeToo campaign that has shown many a screen god to have feet of clay has heads rolling and put the government in the dock for turning a blind eye. The outrage is not new. We saw it in 2012, in the Nirbhaya rape case in Delhi, which hit the nation in the gut. This time too, women spilled out into the streets in Kolkata to 'Reclaim the Night', and took to social media to register their protest in posts and poetry. Opposition parties created a political uproar even as the courts demanded accountability from the government and the hospital authorities. Fuelling the fury was the fact that the crime took place within the precincts of the hospital, in the only place the victim could find to take a rest, despite security at every level and CCTV cameras.

THE RISING TIDE OF CONCERN

India's female labour force participation rate, or the number of women in the active workforce, according to Periodic Labour Force Survey data, was 37 per cent in 2022-23—still among the lowest in the world but showing an upward trend in the past six years. By that estimate, the number of working women in the country would be around 200 million. While agriculture employs the most number of women, 128 million or 64 per cent, the remaining are employed in other sectors, including manufacturing, services and construction. The more educated of the cohort are now employed in fields as diverse as IT and ITeS companies, banking, finance, media, HR, consulting, pharma and telecom, where